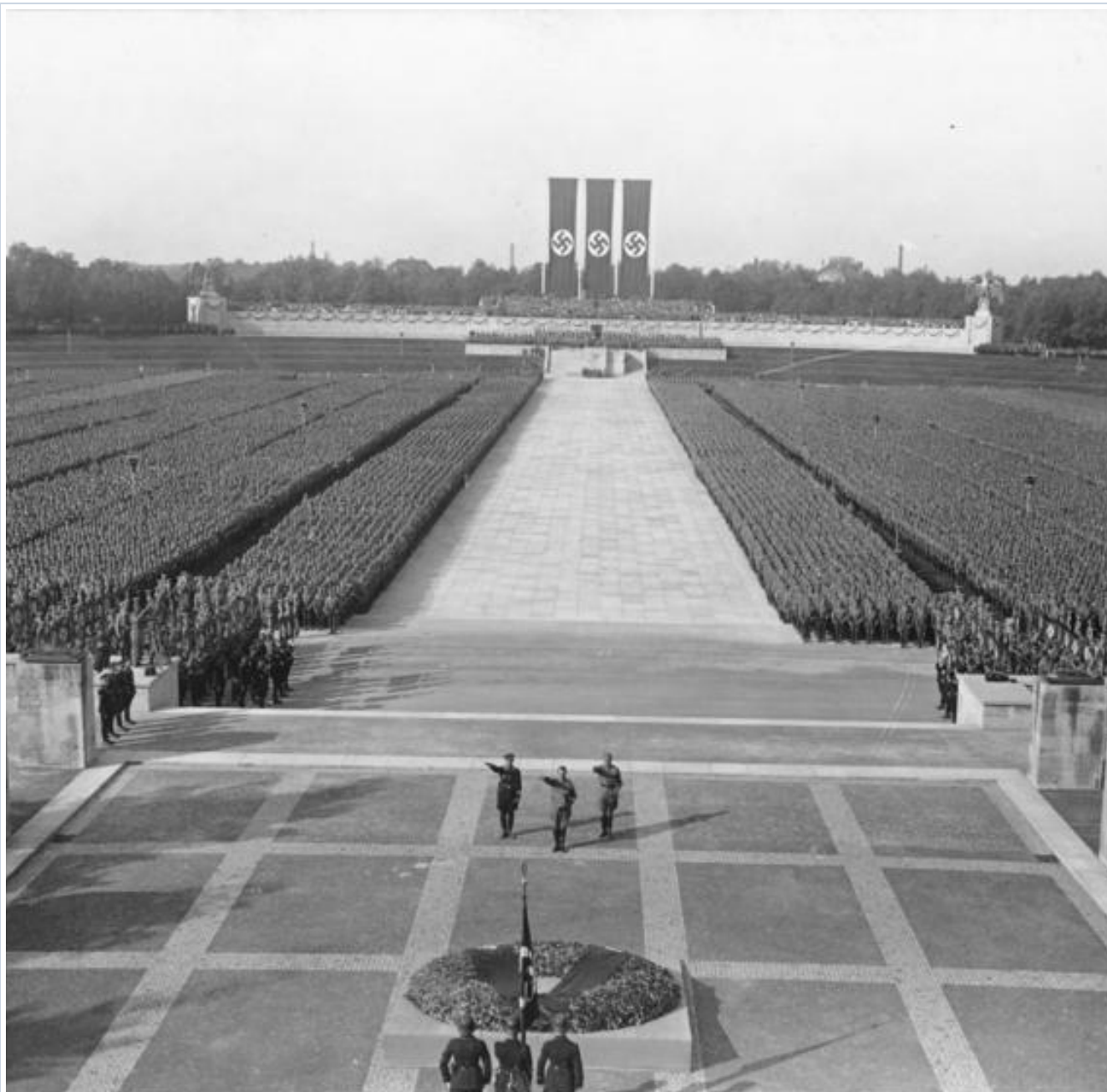


WEIMAR AND NAZI GERMANY, 1918–1939

KEY TOPIC 3: NAZI CONTROL AND DICTATORSHIP, 1933–1939

Student Master Textbook • Core Knowledge, Disciplinary Enquiries & Archival Evidence



Nuremberg, September 1934 (Bundesarchiv Bild 102-16196): Massed formations of over 150,000 SA and SS troops assembled in the Luitpoldarena during the Reich Party Congress, demonstrating the totalitarian regime's staged theatrical power and total control.

Historical
Primary
Photograph

OFFICIAL PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE SPECIFICATION STRUCTURE & SYLLABUS MAPPING (OPTION 31: KT3)

Core syllabus coverage across all four key enquiries:

1. CREATION OF DICTATORSHIP, 1933–34

- Reichstag Fire (Feb 1933) and Emergency Decree; Enabling Act (Mar 1933).
- *Gleichschaltung*: crushing trade unions (May 1933) and banning all other parties (Jul 1933).
- Night of the Long Knives (Jun 1934); death of Hindenburg and the sacred army oath (Aug 1934).

2. POLICE STATE & RELIGION, 1933–39

- Machinery of terror: SS, SD, Gestapo, and the establishment of concentration camps (Dachau 1933).
- Nazification of the legal system: People's Court (*Volksgerichtshof*) and abolition of jury trials.
- Controlling churches: Catholic Concordat (1933), Reich Church, and persecution of the Confessing Church.

3. CONTROLLING ATTITUDES, 1933–39

- Joseph Goebbels and Propaganda Ministry; censorship of press, radio (*Volksempfänger*), and literature.
- The "Hitler Myth" and mass mobilization: annual Nuremberg Rallies and the 1936 Berlin Olympic Games.
- Reich Chamber of Culture: banning "degenerate art" and enforcing monumental classical architecture.

4. OPPOSITION & CONFORMITY, 1933–39

- The reality of conformity: economic rewards, propaganda saturation, and pervasive fear of denunciation.
- Underground political and worker resistance: KPD/SPD leaflets, sabotage, and absenteeism.
- Youth opposition (Edelweiss Pirates, Swing Youth); religious resistance (Niemöller, Bonhoeffer, Galen).

Key Topic 3.1: The Creation of a Dictatorship, 1933–1934

Key Enquiry: From chains to absolute control: How did Hitler completely dismantle the Weimar democracy and forge a totalitarian dictatorship in just 18 months?
• Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE REICHSTAG FIRE & EMERGENCY DECREES (FEB 1933)

ACT 2 THE ENABLING ACT & LEGAL DICTATORSHIP (MARCH 1933)

[1.1] The Reichstag Arson & The Dutch Communist: When Hitler became Chancellor in January 1933, his power was extremely limited: the Nazis held only three cabinet seats, lacked a Reichstag majority, and could be dismissed by President Hindenburg at any moment. On the night of 27 February 1933, six days before fresh elections, the Reichstag building was consumed by fire. A young Dutch communist, Marinus van der Lubbe, was caught at the scene with matches. Hitler and Hermann Göring instantly capitalized on the blaze, declaring it the signal for a nationwide communist revolution.

[1.2] The Decree for the Protection of the People and the State: On 28 February 1933, Hitler persuaded the terrified 85-year-old President Hindenburg to sign the Reichstag Fire Decree under Article 48. The decree permanently suspended all fundamental constitutional civil liberties: freedom of speech, assembly, privacy of postal communications, and freedom of the press. Empowered by emergency authority, Göring unleashed 50,000 auxiliary police (SA and SS), arresting over 4,000 communist leaders and banning all opposition newspapers, effectively paralyzing anti-Nazi campaigning.

[1.3] The Anti-Communist Terror & The Leipzig Trial: Following the decree, Hermann Göring drafted 50,000 SA and SS men as auxiliary police to crush left-wing resistance. Over 4,000 communists were detained, beaten in unofficial cellars, and sent to early makeshift concentration camps like Dachau. In late 1933, the regime staged the Leipzig Trial to convict communist leaders. However, Bulgarian communist Georgi Dimitrov mounted a brilliant courtroom defence, humiliating Göring and forcing the court to acquit him. Enraged by this judicial independence, Hitler resolved to bypass the standard courts altogether.

[2.1] The March 1933 Elections & The Kroll Opera House: Despite violent intimidation, the Nazis failed to secure an outright majority in the 5 March 1933 elections, winning 288 seats (43.9%). To alter the constitution and achieve absolute dictatorial power, Hitler introduced the Enabling Act (*Ermächtigungsgesetz*), requiring a two-thirds parliamentary majority. Hitler banned all 81 elected Communist deputies from attending. Meeting in the Kroll Opera House on 23 March 1933, flanked by armed SA stormtroopers chanting intimidatory death threats, the Catholic Centre Party was persuaded to support the bill after Hitler promised to protect Catholic schools.

[2.2] Democracy Votes Itself Out of Existence: The Enabling Act passed by an overwhelming margin of 444 votes to 94, with only Otto Wels' Social Democrats (SPD) having the courage to vote against it. The act transferred complete legislative and budgetary power to Adolf Hitler's cabinet for four years without Reichstag or presidential consent. By signing away parliamentary authority, the Reichstag formally dissolved German democracy, giving Hitler the legal foundation to coordinate the state under *Gleichschaltung* and establish an unchallengeable totalitarian dictatorship.

[2.3] Gleichschaltung: Crushing Unions & Federalism: Armed with dictatorial decree powers, Hitler systematically destroyed all independent centres of political and civic power. On 2 May 1933, SA stormtroopers raided and shut down all free trade union headquarters, arresting leaders and forcing millions of workers into the Nazi German Labour Front (*DAF*). In July 1933, the Law Against the Formation of Parties made the NSDAP the only legal political organisation in Germany. By January 1934, regional state parliaments were abolished, completing the total destruction of German federalism.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

27 February 1933

The Reichstag Engulfed in Flames on the Night of the Arson



On the evening of 27 February 1933, the German Reichstag was consumed by fire, with flames bursting through the great gilded dome. Hitler and Göring arrived at the scene and immediately claimed the arson was the signal for a nationwide Bolshevik insurrection.

HINGE QUESTION: Did the Reichstag Fire provide Hitler with a genuine security crisis, or an orchestrated pretext to destroy German democracy?

SOURCE B EMERGENCY CONSTITUTIONAL DECREE

28 February 1933

Article 1 of the Reichstag Fire Decree

"Sections 114, 115, 117, 118, 123, 124 and 153 of the Constitution of the German Reich are suspended until further notice. Most importantly, restrictions on personal liberty, on the right of free expression of opinion, including freedom of the press, the right of assembly and association, and violations of the privacy of postal, telegraphic and telephonic communications, and warrants for house-searches... are permissible beyond the legal limits otherwise prescribed."

Signed by President Hindenburg under Article 48 the morning after the fire, this decree permanently stripped German citizens of basic civil liberties and formed the legal cornerstone of the Nazi police state.

HINGE QUESTION: Why was the suspension of civil liberties under the Reichstag Fire Decree far more dangerous than the fire itself?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 3.1

REICHSTAG FIRE DECREE

Emergency law passed 28 Feb 1933 indefinitely suspending personal liberty, freedom of speech, press, and assembly.

ENABLING ACT

Law passed 23 March 1933 giving Hitler power to make laws without Reichstag consent for 4 years, establishing dictatorship.

GLEICHSCHALTUNG

"Coordination"; the systematic nazification of all German political, social, and cultural institutions in 1933.

NIGHT OF THE LONG KNIVES

Purge of 30 June 1934 where Hitler had Ernst Röhm and over 85 SA leaders murdered by the SS to win army loyalty.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

Key Topic 3.1: The Creation of a Dictatorship, 1933–1934

ACT 3	GLEICHSCHALTUNG (COORDINATION) AND CRUSHING OPPOSITION	ACT 4	THE INTERNAL THREAT: THE NIGHT OF THE LONG KNIVES (JUNE 1934)
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[3.1] Armed with the Enabling Act, Hitler began the rapid process of *Gleichschaltung*—bringing all of German society into line. He systematically destroyed all external opposition:

[3.2] * **May 1933 (Trade Unions):** Trade unions were banned, their leaders arrested, and their funds confiscated. Workers were forced into the Nazi-run German Labour Front (DAF). This meant workers could no longer strike against the government.

[3.3] *July 1933 (Political Parties):* Hitler passed the Law Against the Formation of Parties*. All political parties except the NSDAP were officially banned. Germany was now a one-party state.

[3.4] *January 1934 (Local Government):* The 18 regional state governments (Länder*) were stripped of their power, and highly loyal Nazi governors were appointed to run every region directly from Berlin.

[4.1] **The Night of the Long Knives (30 June 1934):** By early 1934, Ernst Röhm's 3-million-strong SA demanded a 'second socialist revolution' and absorption of the regular army (*Reichswehr*). Conservative generals and industrialists warned Hitler they would overthrow him unless the SA was crushed. Allied with Himmler's SS, Hitler launched a ruthless purge: Röhm and hundreds of SA leaders were executed without trial alongside political rivals including Gregor Strasser, former Chancellor Kurt von Schleicher, and Gustav von Kahr. Approximately 400 people were murdered, with Hitler retroactively declaring the killings legal state defence.

[4.2] **The Death of Hindenburg & The Sacred Army Oath:** On 2 August 1934, President von Hindenburg died at age 86. Hitler immediately merged the Chancellorship and Presidency into supreme executive office as *Führer und Reichskanzler*. On the exact same day, every German soldier and officer swore an unconditional sacred oath of obedience not to the constitution or nation, but personally to Adolf Hitler. A national plebiscite on 19 August approved Hitler's absolute powers by 89.9%, eliminating the final constitutional check on single-party totalitarian dictatorship.

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS			ENQUIRY 3.1 SEQUENCE
27 Feb 1933 • The Reichstag Fire Dutch communist Van der Lubbe is arrested; Hitler claims communist plot; Fire Decree suspends civil liberties.	23 Mar 1933 • The Enabling Act Passed Kroll Opera House vote (444 to 94) under SA terror grants Hitler 4-year dictatorial decree powers.	May–Jul 1933 • Gleichschaltung Smashes Rivals Free trade unions dissolved on 2 May; Law Against Formation of Parties on 14 July makes NSDAP sole legal party.	30 Jun 1934 • Night of the Long Knives SS liquidates Röhm, SA leaders, and Schleicher; German Army swears personal oath of unconditional loyalty.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION A

QUESTION 1 • 4 MARKS • 5 MINS

Exam Challenge: Give two things you can infer from Source A about how the Nazi government used the Reichstag Fire. [4 marks]

Specification Technique: State 2 distinct historical inferences directly supported by explicit quotes or visual evidence from Source A.

GRADE 9 ACCURACY

Key Topic 3.2: The Police State and Religion, 1933–1939

Key Enquiry: The architecture of fear: How did Hitler construct a terrifying police state and attempt to crush the moral authority of the German churches? •
Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE MACHINERY OF TERROR: SS, SD, AND GESTAPO

[1.1] 1. The Machinery of Terror: SS, SD, and Gestapo To maintain absolute control, Hitler could not rely on the regular German police forces, which were run by local governments. Instead, he built a terrifying, highly organised 'Police State' directly loyal to the Nazi Party, operating completely outside normal laws.

[1.2] * The SS: Led by Heinrich Himmler, the SS grew from a small bodyguard unit into a massive organisation of deeply loyal, racially "pure" Aryans. By 1936, Himmler was placed in charge of all police forces in Germany. The ruthless 'Death's Head Units' of the SS were responsible for running the concentration camps. *** The SD:** Formed in 1931 by Himmler and run by his ruthless deputy, Reinhard Heydrich, the SD was the intelligence-gathering wing of the party. They kept a massive card index of anyone suspected of opposing the Nazis, spying on everyone from high-ranking politicians to ordinary citizens. *** The Gestapo:** Also commanded by Heydrich, the Gestapo was the non-uniformed Secret State Police. They had the power to tap telephones, open mail, and use **Schutzhaft (Protective Custody)** to arrest people and send them straight to concentration camps without a trial.

[1.3] Advanced Analysis: The RSHA and the 'Myth' of the Gestapo By 1939, Himmler consolidated all these overlapping branches (Gestapo, SD, and criminal police) into a single monstrous umbrella organisation: the **RSHA (Reich Main Security Office)**, overseen by Heydrich. Yet, Nazi propaganda deliberately created the terrifying myth that the Gestapo itself was an enormous, all-seeing organisation with agents on every street corner. In reality, the Gestapo was surprisingly small; in 1939, a major city like Frankfurt only had 28 Gestapo agents for a population of nearly half a million. The true horror of the police state was that it relied on **ordinary citizens**. Roughly 80% of all Gestapo arrests were triggered by voluntary denunciations—neighbours, local block wardens ('Blockleiters'), and even children reporting on each other out of spite, jealousy, or brainwashed loyalty.

ACT 2 THE CO-OPTED COURTS & CONCENTRATION CAMPS

[2.1] 2. Controlling the Legal System Hitler knew that his police state would only work if the courts supported it. He systematically destroyed the independence of the German legal system:

[2.2] * The Judges: All judges were forced to join the **National Socialist League for the Maintenance of the Law**. If a judge did not rule the way the Nazi Party wanted, they were instantly sacked. *** The People's Court:** In 1934, Hitler set up the People's Court ('Volksgerichtshof') to try cases of treason. Juries were abolished. Instead, cases were heard by fanatical Nazi judges, most notoriously the screaming, aggressive Roland Freisler. Trials were held in secret, there was no right to appeal, and the number of death penalties skyrocketed.

[2.3] 3. The Early Concentration Camps The ultimate weapon of the police state was the concentration camp. The first camp, **Dachau**, was opened in 1933. In this early period (1933–39), these were primarily 'political' prisons, not the extermination camps they would later become. Inmates were mostly communists, trade unionists, outspoken journalists, and political rivals. They were used as forced labour, subjected to brutal beatings by SS guards, and deliberately kept in terrible conditions to serve as a terrifying warning to the rest of the population.

[2.4] The People's Court & Freisler Arbitrary Terror: In April 1934, Hitler established the People's Court ('Volksgerichtshof') to handle political treason outside the constitutional judiciary. Defendants had no right to choose counsel, proceedings were secret, and verdicts could not be appealed. Chaired by the fanatical Roland Freisler, the court functioned purely as an instrument of terror, handing down over 5,000 death sentences for defeatist remarks or distributing anti-Nazi leaflets.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

Day of Potsdam, 21 March 1933

Adolf Hitler and President Paul von Hindenburg



Hitler, dressed in formal morning coat, bowing reverently before the aged Field Marshal von Hindenburg at the Garrison Church in Potsdam. This ceremony deliberately forged a symbolic bridge between imperial Prussian militarism and the new Nazi regime.

HINGE QUESTION: How did this visual display of reverence toward Hindenburg successfully reassure conservative elites and military leaders about Hitler's intentions?

SOURCE B EYE-WITNESS ARCHIVAL TESTIMONY

Summer 1933

Report from an Early Political Prisoner at Dachau

"Dachau was opened in March 1933 for political opponents—mostly communists, socialists, and trade unionists. Over the entrance stood the cynical iron slogan: Arbeit Macht Frei (Work Sets You Free). The SS guards maintained reign through arbitrary beatings, twenty-five lashes on the wooden trestle, and summary executions in the gravel pits. Knowledge of what happened at Dachau spread by whispered rumour across Munich, paralyzing all urge to protest."

Testimony describing the brutal discipline inside the Third Reich's first concentration camp, established by Heinrich Himmler near Munich as a training ground for SS guards.

HINGE QUESTION: Why was the public awareness of concentration camps like Dachau vital to enforcing conformity without requiring millions of police officers?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 3.2

GESTAPO

The Secret State Police (*Geheime Staatspolizei*), operating without judicial restraint to eliminate political opposition.

SCHUTZSTAFFEL (SS)

The elite Nazi protection squad led by Himmler, responsible for running concentration camps and internal security.

PEOPLE'S COURT

Volksgerichtshof: special Nazi court created in 1934 to try political treason cases with handpicked Nazi judges and no juries.

CONCORDAT (1933)

Pact between Hitler and the Pope agreeing the Catholic Church would stay out of politics in exchange for religious freedom.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

Key Topic 3.2: The Police State and Religion, 1933–1939

ACT 3 CONTROLLING THE CHURCHES: THE CATHOLIC CONCORDAT

ACT 4 CONTROLLING THE CHURCHES: THE PROTESTANTS

[3.1] 4. Controlling the Churches: The Catholic Concordat

Religion was a massive threat to Hitler. Christianity preached peace, forgiveness, and loyalty to God over any earthly leader. In 1933, one-third of Germans were Catholic, and two-thirds were Protestant.

[4.1] 5. Controlling the Churches: The Protestants The Protestant churches were heavily divided. Hitler united the pro-Nazi Protestants into a single **Reich Church**, led by Ludwig Müller (the 'Reich Bishop'). Its members called themselves 'German Christians'. They wore Nazi uniforms, hung swastikas inside their churches, and demanded that the Old Testament of the Bible be banned because of its Jewish origins.

[3.2] Initially, Hitler tried to compromise with the Catholic Church. In **July 1933**, he signed the **Concordat** with the Pope. The Pope agreed that Catholic priests would stay out of German politics, and in return, Hitler promised not to interfere with Catholic schools or youth groups.

[3.3] However, Hitler quickly broke this treaty. By 1935, he had set up a dedicated **Ministry of Church Affairs** under Hanns Kerrl to systematically weaken religious power. In 1936, the state aggressively campaigned to remove crucifixes from Catholic classrooms, Catholic schools were forcibly closed, and the Catholic Youth League was banned. In 1937, a furious Pope Pius XI issued a scorching public letter called *Mit brennender Sorge* '(With Burning Concern)'. It was secretly smuggled into Germany and read out in every Catholic church, openly condemning Hitler's broken promises and his dangerous "myth of race and blood."

[4.2] In disgust, a brave First World War U-boat commander turned pastor named Martin Niemöller set up the **Pastors' Emergency League (PEL)**, which evolved into the rival **Confessional Church** in 1934. Over 6,000 Protestant pastors joined Niemöller, alongside theologians like Dietrich Bonhoeffer (who secretly trained illegal pastors), in preaching against Nazi interference in religion. The Nazis responded with brutal force: Niemöller was arrested in 1937 and eventually sent to Sachsenhausen concentration camp, and hundreds of his pastors were imprisoned.

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

ENQUIRY 3.2 SEQUENCE

22 Mar 1933 • Dachau Camp Opens

Himmler establishes the first model concentration camp near Munich to imprison communist and socialist opponents.

20 Jul 1933 • The Reichskonkordat

Vatican treaty guarantees Catholic freedom in worship and schools provided clergy remain out of political activity.

17 Jun 1936 • Police Unified under Himmler

Himmler is named Chief of German Police; Gestapo and SS are integrated into an unaccountable terror apparatus.

14 Mar 1937 • Papal Encyclical Condemnation

Pope Pius XI issues *Mit brennender Sorge* condemning Nazi paganism and race idolatry; read from all pulpits.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION A

QUESTION 2 • 12 MARKS • 18 MINS

Exam Challenge: Explain why the Nazi police state was able to maintain control in Germany between 1933 and 1939. [12 marks]

Specification Stimulus: (1) The Gestapo • (2) Block Wardens • Deploy 3 PEEL paragraphs with precise causal evidence.

GRADE 9 CAUSATION

Key Topic 3.3: Controlling and Influencing Attitudes, 1933–1939

Key Enquiry: The war for the German mind: How did Joseph Goebbels use censorship, mass propaganda, and the arts to brainwash an entire nation? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE MINISTRY OF PROPAGANDA & PRESS CENSORSHIP

ACT 2 MASS MOBILISATION: RADIO, RALLIES & CINEMA

[1.1] 1. Goebbels and the Ministry of Propaganda In March 1933, Hitler appointed Joseph Goebbels as the Minister of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda. Goebbels was a mastermind of psychological manipulation. He understood that for propaganda to work, it had to be inescapable but often subtle. His goal was the 'Gleichschaltung' (coordination) of the German mind—ensuring that every time a citizen opened a newspaper, turned on the radio, or went to the cinema, they absorbed the Nazi message.

[1.2] 2. Censorship: Crushing the Truth Goebbels systematically destroyed free speech in Germany to ensure no one could hear anti-Nazi viewpoints:

[1.3] The Press: In October 1933, Goebbels passed the *Schriftleitergesetz** (Editor's Law), making newspaper editors legally responsible for what was printed, effectively forcing them to censor themselves. Furthermore, the official Nazi publishing house, the **Eher Verlag**, systematically bought up independent newspapers. By 1939, the Nazis directly owned or controlled 82% of all newspapers in Germany. * **Literature:** In May 1933, Goebbels organised massive "Book Burnings" across Germany. Brainwashed university students threw over 20,000 books written by Jews, communists, and pacifists (like Albert Einstein and Karl Marx) into massive bonfires in Berlin.

[2.1] 3. Propaganda: Mass Rallies and the Radio Having silenced the opposition, Goebbels flooded Germany with Nazi ideology:

[2.2] The Radio: Goebbels realised that hearing Hitler's charismatic voice was the most effective way to brainwash the public. He subsidised the mass production of the **Volksempfänger*** (People's Receiver). These radios were deliberately designed with a short range so they could not pick up foreign stations like the BBC. By 1939, over 70% of German homes owned one. Crucially, listening was enforced: loudspeakers were erected in streets and factories, and sirens would sound to halt all work when Hitler made a major speech. * **Mass Rallies:** Every September, the Nazis held a massive rally in Nuremberg. These were carefully choreographed theatrical spectacles. Albert Speer, Hitler's favourite architect, designed the 'Cathedral of Light' using 130 anti-aircraft searchlights pointing into the night sky, creating a semi-religious, overwhelming atmosphere of power and unity. * **Film:** Cinemas were immensely popular. Goebbels commissioned director Leni Riefenstahl to make 'Triumph of the Will' (documenting the 1934 Nuremberg Rally), which is still studied today as a masterpiece of propaganda. However, 80% of Nazi films were actually comedies or dramas that just had subtle anti-Semitic or pro-Aryan messages woven into the plot.

SOURCE A OFFICIAL PARTY DISPATCH

10 May 1933

The Burning of "Un-German" Books on Berlin Opernplatz

"At midnight, over 25,000 volumes of un-German books were thrown into the blazing bonfire by student stormtroopers. As each bundle was hurled into the flames, a speaker proclaimed: 'Against decadence and moral decay! For discipline and decency in the family and the State! I consign to the flames the writings of Karl Marx, Sigmund Freud, and Heinrich Mann!' Minister Goebbels addressed the crowd, declaring that the era of Jewish intellectualism had ended forever."

Orchestrated by the German Students' Union and Goebbels' ministry, nationwide book burnings physically purged modernist, pacifist, and Jewish literature from public university libraries.

HINGE QUESTION: What does the public burning of books reveal about the regime's view of intellectual freedom and the purpose of culture?

SOURCE B CONTEMPORARY ADVERTISING SLOGAN

1933

The People's Receiver (Volksempfänger VE301)

"ALL GERMANY HEARS THE FÜHRER ON THE PEOPLE'S RECEIVER!"

The radio must belong to every German household. It costs only 76 Reichsmarks, payable in easy monthly instalments. The radio brings the words of our Leader directly to your family hearth. Remember: listening to foreign radio broadcasts is a crime against the security of the nation!"

Promotional campaign for the mass-produced Volksempfänger radio, which had its tuning range strictly limited to German domestic frequencies to prevent citizens from hearing foreign news broadcasts.

HINGE QUESTION: How did modern domestic technology allow the Nazi regime to penetrate the private lives and thoughts of ordinary citizens?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 3.3

JOSEPH GOEBBELS

Minister of Propaganda and Enlightenment, controlling press, radio, cinema, literature, art, and public rallies.

VOLKSEMPFÄNGER

Cheap, mass-produced "People's Receiver" radio pre-set to Nazi stations so all Germans could hear Hitler's speeches.

REICH CHAMBER OF CULTURE

Nazi body headed by Goebbels requiring all artists, writers, and journalists to register; Jews and dissidents were excluded.

1936 BERLIN OLYMPICS

International sports event used as a propaganda spectacular to present Germany as a modern, peaceful, and Aryan Great Power.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

Key Topic 3.3: Controlling and Influencing Attitudes, 1933–1939

ACT 3 THE 1936 BERLIN OLYMPICS

ACT 4 CONTROLLING CULTURE AND THE ARTS

[3.1] 4. The 1936 Berlin Olympics The 1936 Olympic Games provided Hitler with the ultimate global stage to showcase the "superiority" of the Aryan race and the efficiency of the Nazi state.

[3.2] * The Deception: Goebbels carefully paused the regime's brutality. Violent anti-Semitic newspapers like 'Der Stürmer' were temporarily removed from newsstands, and "Jews Not Wanted" signs were taken down. Foreign visitors left genuinely impressed by the clean, prosperous, and highly organised "New Germany". *** The International Failure vs. Domestic Success:** Hitler's primary goal was to prove Aryan racial supremacy. Internationally, this was undermined by the African-American athlete Jesse Owens, who won four gold medals. However, for the domestic German audience, the propaganda was a massive triumph: Germany dominated the overall medal table, winning 33 gold medals (far ahead of America's 24), which Goebbels used as 'proof' of Aryan superiority.

[4.1] 5. Controlling Culture and the Arts Hitler fancied himself an artist, and he believed that culture should reflect the heroic, traditional values of the German race. In September 1933, the **Reich Chamber of Culture** was set up. If you wanted to publish a book, sell a painting, or play in an orchestra, you 'had' to be a member. Jews and political opponents were banned.

[4.2] Art: Modern, abstract art was despised by Hitler and banned as **Entartete Kunst*** (Degenerate Art). In 1937, the Nazis held a massive 'Degenerate Art Exhibition' in Munich, where banned paintings were hung crookedly and surrounded by insulting graffiti to encourage the public to mock them. Instead, the Nazis promoted heroic, realistic paintings of muscular Aryan soldiers and fertile peasant women. *** Architecture:** Hitler favoured monumental, neoclassical architecture (huge stone buildings with classical pillars). Albert Speer designed buildings that were deliberately massive to make the individual feel small and the State feel eternal. *** Music:** Jewish composers (like Mendelssohn) were completely banned. American Jazz was outlawed because it was seen as "black music". Instead, Germans were encouraged to listen to traditional German composers like **Richard Wagner** and Beethoven.

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

ENQUIRY 3.3 SEQUENCE

13 Mar 1933 • Propaganda Ministry Created

Joseph Goebbels heads the Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda, coordinating press, art, and cinema.

10 May 1933 • Public Book Burnings

Nazi students burn over 25,000 "un-German" books in Berlin Opernplatz, purging pacifist and Jewish authors.

18 Aug 1933 • The Volksempfänger Released

Goebbels introduces cheap VE301 radio; 70% of households own radios by 1939, broadcasting party rallies.

1–16 Aug 1936 • The Berlin Olympic Games

Massive propaganda spectacle displays Nazi modernity; African-American Jesse Owens wins 4 sprint golds.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION B

QUESTION 3(a) • 8 MARKS • 12 MINS

Exam Challenge: How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into Nazi methods of controlling and influencing attitudes in the years 1933–1939? [8 marks]

Specification Technique: Interrogate Content, Provenance (Nature, Origin, Purpose), and Context for both sources before reaching a weighed judgment.

**GRADE 9
UTILITY**

Key Topic 3.4: Opposition, Resistance and Conformity, 1933–1939

Key Enquiry: Why was there so little active opposition to the Nazi regime, and how did underground networks, workers, and young people attempt to resist? •
Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence

ACT 1 THE ILLUSION OF TOTAL SUPPORT: WHY DID MOST PEOPLE CONFORM?

[1.1] 1. The Illusion of Total Support: Why did most people conform? Looking back, it is easy to ask why millions of Germans didn't rise up against Hitler. The reality is that active opposition was incredibly dangerous. Most Germans conformed for two main reasons:

[1.2] * Genuine Support: By 1939, Hitler was genuinely popular with many Germans. He had smashed the hated Treaty of Versailles, rebuilt the army, and seemingly created an 'economic miracle' by drastically reducing unemployment. Many were willing to turn a blind eye to the brutality of the police state because they felt the Nazis were restoring national pride. *** Fear and the Scale of Repression:** The Gestapo and the block wardens terrified people into submission. Between 1933 and 1939, approximately **1.3 million Germans** were sent to concentration camps for political offenses, and another 300,000 fled the country entirely.

[1.3] 2. Underground Political and Worker Resistance When Hitler banned all rival political parties in 1933, opposition was forced underground.

[1.4] * The SPD and the 'Sopade': The Social Democratic Party leadership fled into exile. From abroad, they relied on a secret network of informants inside Germany to write the **Sopade reports**. These intelligence reports detailed the true mood of the working classes, proving that not everyone was completely brainwashed by Goebbels' propaganda. *** The Communists (KPD) and Workers:** The KPD continued to secretly print anti-Nazi leaflets. Furthermore, because Trade Unions were banned, industrial workers resisted in more subtle ways. They engaged in **passive resistance** and **sabotage**: deliberately working slowly ('slow-working'), calling in sick (absenteeism), or secretly damaging factory machinery to disrupt the Nazi economy. In 1936, there were even lightning strikes over high food prices.

ACT 2 ADVANCED ANALYSIS: LONE-WOLF, ARMY, AND RELIGIOUS RESISTANCE

[2.1] Advanced Analysis: Elite Army and Religious Resistance: Not all resistance came from underground working-class cells; critical opposition emerged from traditional institutional elites, high-ranking military commanders, and ecclesiastical leaders who possessed the administrative leverage to challenge Nazi totalitarian hegemony.

[2.2] Elite Army Discontent: General Ludwig Beck, Chief of Staff of the German Army, actively opposed Hitler's aggressive expansionist foreign policy, fearing it would drag Germany into a catastrophic world war. In 1938, Beck resigned in protest and began covertly organising anti-Nazi military conspiracies with conservative diplomats and intelligence officers.

[2.3] The Confessional Church & Papal Encyclical: In 1934, Pastor Martin Niemöller and Dietrich Bonhoeffer founded the **Confessional Church** to defy Nazi control and the 'Aryan Paragraph' in religion. Despite the arrest of over 800 pastors, churchmen continued preaching against state paganism. In March 1937, Pope Pius XI issued the encyclical '*Mit brennender Sorge*' ('With Burning Anxiety'), smuggled into Germany and read from Catholic pulpits nationwide to openly condemn racial idolatry, neo-pagan state myths, and systematic Gestapo terror against believers. Protestant martyrs like Paul Schneider were tortured to death in Buchenwald for refusing to salute the swastika, proving that religious convictions represented an unbreakable barrier against absolute totalitarian control.

SOURCE A GESTAPO INTELLIGENCE REPORT

Cologne, December 1943

Gestapo Dossier on the Edelweiss Pirates in Cologne

"These adolescents, aged 14 to 17, congregate on street corners and in taverns, openly flouting Hitler Youth discipline. They wear non-regulation clothing—checked shirts and badges of Party hymns. More flower—and sing satirical, filthy parodies of Party hymns. More dangerously, they distribute subversive communist leaflets and have ambushed Hitler Youth patrols after dark. Their insolence is corrupting other youth; rigorous police counter-measures must be enforced immediately."

Internal Gestapo summary of investigations into working-class youth gangs in the Rhineland, documenting how non-conformist adolescents actively resisted Nazi totalitarian control.

HINGE QUESTION: What does the Gestapo report reveal about the regime's deep anxiety over youth rebellion even during wartime?

SOURCE B ECCLESIASTICAL PASTORAL

Summer 1941 (referencing 1930s abuses)

LETTER

Bishop Clemens August Graf von Galen Condemns the Gestapo

"None of us is certain, though he be the most innocent and conscientious citizen, that he may not any day be dragged out of his home, arrested without trial, and thrown into a concentration camp... I demand justice! The physical destruction of innocent people, whether insane or politically suspect, is a violation of the sacred law of God which no mortal authority may override!"

Bishop von Galen of Münster openly attacked Gestapo terror and the T4 euthanasia programme from the pulpit. His sermons were so widely copied that the regime dared not execute him for fear of alienating Catholic soldiers.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did the Nazi regime tolerate open defiance from high-ranking Catholic bishops while ruthlessly executing working-class resisters?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 3.4

EDELWEISS PIRATES

Working-class youth groups in western Germany who dropped out of Hitler Youth, sang parody songs, and attacked Nazi patrols.

SWING YOUTH

Middle-class teenagers who defied Nazi rules by listening to banned American jazz, wearing English fashion, and dancing in clubs.

CONFESSING CHURCH

Protestant movement formed by Niemöller and Bonhoeffer in 1934 opposing Nazi attempts to unify churches into a Reich Church.

GEORG ELSER

German carpenter who acted alone in attempting to assassinate Hitler with a concealed bomb in Munich in November 1939.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

Key Topic 3.4: Opposition, Resistance and Conformity, 1933–1939

ACT 3 YOUTH OPPOSITION: THE EDELWEISS PIRATES

ACT 4 YOUTH OPPOSITION: THE SWING YOUTH

[3.1] 3. Youth Opposition: The Edelweiss Pirates The Hitler Youth became compulsory in 1936. While many enjoyed it initially, as it became increasingly strict, militaristic, and focused on endless drilling, a counter-culture emerged. The **Edelweiss Pirates** emerged in the late 1930s (made up of local groups like the 'Navajos' in Cologne, or the 'Roving Dudes' in Essen). They were primarily **working-class** teenagers. They rebelled by:

[3.2] * Wearing their hair long and dressing in American-style checked shirts and white socks. * Going on weekend hikes in the countryside to escape the suffocating control of the Nazi block wardens. * Singing banned songs (often changing the lyrics of Hitler Youth songs to mock the regime). * Taunting, ambushing, and physically beating up Hitler Youth patrols.

[4.1] 4. Youth Opposition: The Swing Youth While the Pirates were working-class, the **Swing Youth** were largely **middle and upper-class** teenagers in big cities like Berlin and Hamburg. They had the wealth to own record players and rebelled culturally rather than violently.

[4.2] * They illegally listened to banned American Jazz and Swing music (such as Glenn Miller), which the Nazis despised as "black" and "Jewish" music. * They dressed in sharp 'English' styles—boys carried umbrellas and wore tailored suits, while girls wore makeup (which the Nazis banned, as they wanted women to have a natural, 'peasant' look). * They organised illegal underground dances, attended by thousands, where they jitterbugged and smoked.

[4.3] 5. The Nazi Reaction to Youth Opposition Before the outbreak of war in 1939, the Nazi response to these youth groups was relatively lenient. The Gestapo would occasionally break up Swing Youth dances, confiscate record players, or arrest Edelweiss Pirates, shave their heads, and give them a severe beating before releasing them. The Nazis did not want to send thousands of young, healthy Aryans to concentration camps. '(Note: This would change drastically during WWII, when youth opposition became more political and the Nazi punishments became lethal).'

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

ENQUIRY 3.4 SEQUENCE

May 1934 • Barmen Declaration
Pastor Niemöller and Karl Barth establish Confessional Church, rejecting state control by the Nazi "German Christians".

1935–1938 • Underground Left-Wing Cells
Banned KPD and SPD cells print anti-Nazi leaflets (*Rote Fahne*) and coordinate slow-downs in armaments factories.

1937–1939 • Edelweiss Pirates & Swing Kids
Working-class Pirates beat up Hitler Youths; middle-class Swing Youth listen to banned Anglo-American jazz.

8 Nov 1939 • Elser's Beer Hall Bomb
Carpenter Georg Elser detonates a bomb at the Bürgerbräukeller in Munich; Hitler departs 13 minutes early.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION B

QUESTION 3(d) • 16 MARKS + 4 SPaG • 25 MINS

Exam Challenge: How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about religious opposition to the Nazi regime? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. [16 marks]

Specification Technique: Weigh Interpretation 1 against Interpretation 2; deploy precise contextual evidence; sustain a criteria-led historical verdict.

**GRADE 9
VERDICT**

KEY TOPIC 3 REVISION SPINE: CORE KNOWLEDGE & EXAM STRATEGY

Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9–1) History • Paper 3 Option 31 (1H10/31)

1. KEY CHRONOLOGY • CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

KEY CHRONOLOGY

27 Feb 1933: The Reichstag Fire: Dutch communist Van der Lubbe arrested; Hitler blames KPD and initiates mass arrests.	28 Feb 1933: Reichstag Fire Decree: Civil liberties suspended; 4,000 communists jailed; police terror legalized.	23 Mar 1933: Enabling Act Passed: Passed 444 to 94 in Kroll Opera House; grants Hitler dictatorial power to bypass Reichstag.
2 May 1933: Trade Unions Banned: SA stormtroopers seize union offices; replaced by state German Labour Front (DAF).	14 Jul 1933: One-Party State Enacted: Law Against Formation of Parties; NSDAP declared sole legal political movement.	20 Jul 1933: Catholic Concordat Signed: Pope Pius XI signs pact with Hitler, neutralizing Catholic Centre Party political opposition.
30 Jun 1934: Night of the Long Knives: SS murders Ernst Röhm, 85+ SA leaders, and Schleicher, securing military loyalty.	2 Aug 1934: Death of Hindenburg: Hitler merges Chancellor and President offices, proclaiming himself <i>Führer und Reichskanzler</i> .	19 Aug 1934: Sacred Army Oath: Reichswehr soldiers swear personal oath of unconditional obedience to Adolf Hitler.
24 Apr 1934: People's Court Created: <i>Volksgerichtshof</i> created to try treason; eliminates right to fair trial and jury.	17 Jun 1936: Himmler Appointed Police Chief: SS and Gestapo unified into a single centralized national terror apparatus.	1–16 Aug 1936: Berlin Olympic Games: Spectacular propaganda display showcases Nazi efficiency and peaceful international standing.

2. CORE SPECIFICATION THEMES

SPECIFICATION REVIEW

I. LEGAL REVOLUTION & GLEICHSCHALTUNG Hitler established dictatorship not by violent putsch, but through legal decrees. The Reichstag Fire Decree and Enabling Act provided constitutional cloaks for banning trade unions, political parties, and state parliaments within six months.	II. THE SS-POLICE TERROR APPARATUS Heinrich Himmler unified the SS, SD, and Gestapo into an extra-legal terror network. Unchecked by judicial review, the Gestapo used protective custody and concentration camps (Dachau) to deter dissent, aided by voluntary civilian denunciations.	III. CULTURAL MONOPOLISATION & THE HITLER MYTH Joseph Goebbels controlled every medium of expression via the Reich Chamber of Culture. The Volksempfänger brought radio into 70% of homes, while the "Hitler Myth" elevated Hitler above criticism as an infallible, selfless national saviour.	IV. CONFORMITY & FRAGMENTED RESISTANCE Most Germans conformed due to restored economic stability, foreign policy triumphs, and pervasive fear. Opposition (Edelweiss Pirates, Swing Youth, Confessing Church, Georg Elser) remained heroic but fragmented, failing to threaten the regime.
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3. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE & EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY

EXAM STRATEGY • Q3(B,C,D)

INTERPRETATION 1: THE TOTALITARIAN POLICE STATE (BRACHER / HILDEBRAND) The Third Reich was a ruthless totalitarian dictatorship characterized by a rigid top-down command structure, omnipresent secret police surveillance, systematic media monopoly, and total subordination of all civil society to Hitler's will.		INTERPRETATION 2: POLYCRACY & STRUCTURAL CHAOS (MOMMSEN / BROSZAT) Hitler was a "weak dictator" presiding over a chaotic web of competing bureaucratic empires (SS, ministries, Gauleiters). Subordinates engaged in "working towards the Führer", driving cumulative radicalization without direct central coordination.		
Q1: INFERENCE [4m] 5 Mins • 2 Inferences + Quotes	Q2: CAUSATION [12m] 15 Mins • 3 PEEL Causal Factors	Q3(a): UTILITY [8m] 12 Mins • Content, NOP & Context	Q3(b/c): VIEWS [8m] 10 Mins • Differences & Reasons	Q3(d): VERDICT [16+4m] 25 Mins • Balanced Evaluation

4. SYNOPTIC ASSESSMENT • HISTORICAL VERDICT

EVALUATION & SIGNIFICANCE

THE DISMANTLING OF THE RULE OF LAW: Hitler systematically replaced constitutional legality with arbitrary Führer decrees. The creation of the People's Court and the removal of judicial review meant that the state could detain, torture, and execute any citizen without legal recourse.	THE BALANCE OF CONSENT AND TERROR: While concentration camps and Gestapo terror brutally neutralized political dissidents, millions of ordinary Germans actively consented to the regime because it restored full employment, rebuilt national pride, and promoted social order.	THE ISOLATION OF RESISTANCE: Pre-war resistance failed not because Germans lacked courage, but because the regime atomised society. Denunciations created profound mutual distrust, while the oath of loyalty bound the army, civil service, and judiciary inextricably to Hitler.
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5. INTERACTIVE QUIZZING HUB • SCAN WITH SMARTPHONE CAMERA

20-QUESTION PRACTICE QUIZZES

KT3.1 Creation of Dictatorship  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT3.2 Police State & Religion  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT3.3 Controlling Attitudes  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	KT3.4 Opposition & Resistance  INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ
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